

Dragon Naturally Speaking 9 Close-To-Perfect Voice Recognition!

Speaking to your computer might seem silly, but it might just be the most sensible thing to do with Dragon Naturally Speaking 9. Let's take a quick look at how effective it really is.

We installed the software on our test bed: an Intel Pentium 4 HT, 1 GB of RAM, and a Creative Audigy2 sound card.

Training is, of course, required, and it involves a good amount of patience on your part—it can take days. Any mumbling or drop of quality in your speaking style can mess it up.

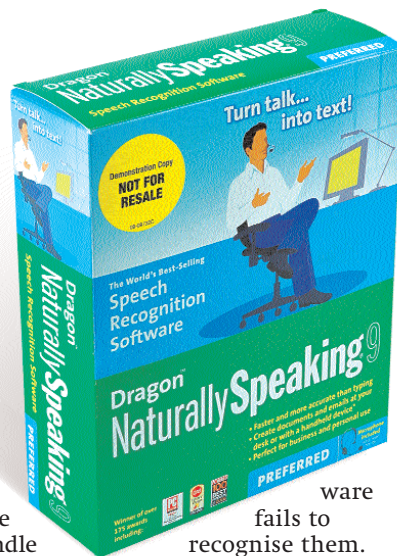
We used the software for over a week to gauge performance. The detection is close to perfect, but occasional error corrections are needed. Small words confused it even during the training ses-

sions. The numerical voice recognition, however, was both fast and accurate.

The application consumed around 200 MB of RAM, with some 50 to 60 per cent CPU utilisation. Very long sentences can cause slowdown and inaccuracy.

Moving on to features, the software has the ability to let you use voice commands to handle almost all Windows applications. There are five modes for various types of dictation, such as numerical entry, text entry, and voice commands.

Making random selections can be done by saying "Select" followed by the words. This is helpful in fixing mistakes in the text. You can add custom words to the database if the soft-



ware fails to recognise them. The text to speech conversion isn't impressive, and sounds like the Microsoft Speech Engine.

RATINGS

Performance	★★★★☆
Features	★★★★☆
Ease of use	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

Good help is provided by both the printed booklet and also the good number of voice tutorials, which explain many features in detail. The bundle includes a small headset which is OK, but very uncomfortable for long sittings because of its small size.

Vista support was recently added in the 9.5 update of the software.

Overall, the voice recognition is effective once you've gone through the training. We think it could have been lighter on the system, and that a better headset could be supplied. Overall, highly recommended for people who are slow at typing or hate typing a lot.

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Price: Rs 11,542

Symantec Backup Exec System Recovery—Desktop Edition Wish Backup Worries Away!

Symantec has released an excellent product to automate all your system backup and restoring tasks—a product that might well kill Windows' System Restore!

The main feature is, it lets you create a backup of your entire hard drive, or a partition, to an image. The inbuilt scheduler automates the backup process. You can schedule a backup for any date and time.

The software also lets you create new backups and only store the last, set number of updates.

Backed-up disk images can be restored onto a disk or partition. You can use the Recover Files or Folders task, where only selected folders and files will be extracted to a specified destination. Mounting of the disk images as a

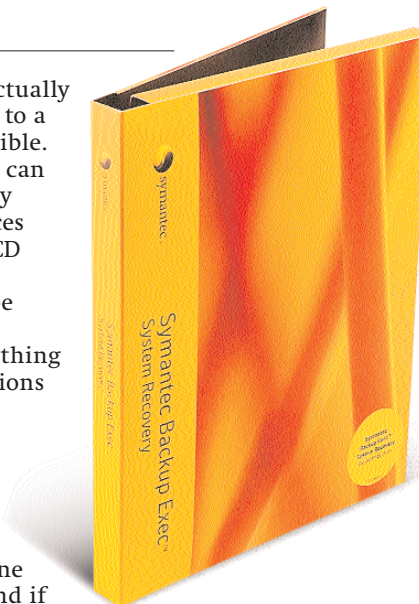
partition without actually restoring the image to a location is also possible.

The software CD can be used as a recovery disk. Network services are enabled as the CD boots.

A lot more can be done through the recovery disk—everything from altering partitions to scanning your machine for viruses using an external virus definition database.

Installation is so simple, it can be done by a five-year-old. And if you're expecting a complicated interface, you'll be relieved to see that it's anything but.

Still, an advanced mode is in place for those who want more control. A sidebar contains the task list as well as help topics.



RATINGS

Performance	★★★★☆
Features	★★★★☆
Ease of use	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

The electronic manual and the printed documentation are the same; overall, the help is comprehensive and easy to understand.

Simply set the software to back up data every day when you log off, or whenever new software is installed on your PC—and never worry about losing data any more!

In sum, Symantec Backup Exec System Recovery is Norton Ghost with a few added features and a non-complicated interface.

Regular home users will like it, though the price tag of \$69 (Rs 3,100) is a bit on the higher side.

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Price: Rs. \$69 (Rs 3,100)